SYNAPTIC SHARDS

SCENE ONE:

Description: Night has settled heavily over the district. Outside, a bitter wind drives acid rain against the steel walls of a worn-down Kabuki dive bar. The neon sign above the door flickers endlessly. Kael steps inside. Warmth greets him but not comfort. Conversations fade the moment he enters. Eyes follow him, then quickly look away. The smell of stale synth-alc, damp chrome, and something unspoken fills the air. He takes a seat in the far corner. Back to the wall. Always. A hooded man approaches. Slow. Careful. He sits across without asking.

Dialogue(Eddie): You're late, Kael. Or maybe I'm early. I can't... I can't tell where the clock is anymore.

Dialogue(Kael): You look like a fried motherboard, Eddie. I'm looking for the crew. They were supposed to meet me at the extraction point.

Dialogue(Eddie): The crew... yeah. I have the data. Somewhere. But my synapses are misfiring. Everything is a glitch. The memories are locked behind a temporal wall. I'm disconnected.

Dialogue(Kael): Cut the cryptic crap. Where are they?.

Dialogue(Eddie): I need to re-sync. I need a hit of Chronos-V. Pure stuff. It's the only thing that'll dilate the time-stream enough for me to pull the coordinates out of my sub-processor. Without it, those boys are ghosts in the machine.

Dialogue(Kael): Chronos-V? That's high-grade neuro-chem. I'm not a dealer, Eddie.

Dialogue(Eddie): Then you're not finding your team. Look, I know where a stash is. A Scavenger nest out in the Flooded District. They've got the injectors and the Zero-G pipe needed to smoke it. Get me the hit, and I'll give you every location in my head.

Choices:

1. Fine. I'll go to the Flooded District. **(Go to SCENE TWO)**
2. You're too far gone. I'll find them myself. **(Kael leaves the conversation)**
3. This better be worth the heat I'm going to catch. **(Go to SCENE THREE)**

SCENE TWO:

Description: The rain in Night City doesn't wash anything away; it just turns the grime into a liquid. Kael stands at the edge of the Coastview pier. The "lake" here is a graveyard of half-submerged skyscrapers and rusted corporate logos. Kael unties a rusted motorboat—the modern-day cano—and kicks the engine into a coughing life. He navigates through the jagged metal teeth of the district toward a small, artificial island that used to be a high-end corpo-resort. Now, it's a "Scavenger" nest. The air smells of salt, rotting plastic, and the metallic tang of blood. As Kael steps onto the slick concrete of the island, the red optics of Scavenger drones flicker to life in the darkness.

Dialogue(Kael): Great. Scavs. The bottom feeders of the food chain. Always looking for spare parts.

Description: Kael draws his high-caliber revolver. Combat sequence between Kael and the Scavengers guarding the chemical stash. After the fight, Kael kicks open a reinforced crate in the resort's old lobby. Inside, he finds the Chronos-V injectors and a "Zero-G" specialized pipe. He notices a "jelly-ish" residue on one of the injectors—biological waste from a botched experiment.

Dialogue(Kael): Dirty stuff. Eddie's brain is going to feel like a short-circuiting server after this.

Description: Kael heads back to the boat, the chemical injectors secured in his vest. He returns to *The Deep State* bar where Eddie is still twitching in the corner.

SCENE THREE:

Dialogue(Kael): Here's your ticket to the moon, Eddie. Chronos-V. Pure enough to melt your chrome.

Description: Eddie's hands shake as he grabs the Zero-G pipe. He takes a long hit. His eyes roll back, glowing with a flickering, sickly violet light. The floor seems to shake as Eddie's neuro-link starts to dump data directly into Kael's HUD.

Dialogue(Eddie): Finally... I am free! The threads are connecting. Mick... he's in Westbrook. Being fried for his lies. Slim... he's at the bottom of a trash shaft in North Oak. Iron Pete... locked in his own shop in Watson. And the twins... Jax and Dax... they're drinking their lives away in the Badlands.

Dialogue(Kael): One mess at a time.

Choices:

1. Mick first. I want to see how much of a "hero" he's being at the brothel. **(Go to SCENE FOUR)**
2. Slim is in a hole. Better get him out before he's recycled. **(Go to SCENE FIVE)**
3. Iron Pete needs his tools. I need a gunsmith. **(Go to SCENE SIX)**
4. Jax and Dax. I'll start with the twins and the whiskey. **(Go to SCENE SEVEN)**

SCENE FOUR:

Description: *Clouds* is a high-end dollhouse where the elite come to forget themselves, but the back rooms smell of ozone and fear. The air is thick with expensive pheromones and the hum of neural-link processors. Kael walks past the main floor, heading toward the private "Screaming Rooms" in the back. He finds Mick strapped into a high-voltage neuro-torture chair. Four women from the Moxes gang stand around him, their cyber-claws humming with thermal energy. Mick's optics are flickering wildly; he looks like he's been through a dozen "bad trips" in the last hour.

Dialogue(Moxie Leader): Another step and I cook his pre-frontal cortex, merc. This "Romeo" promised my girls five permanent residency slots in the Orbital Colonies. All he actually had was a maxed-out credit line and a mouth full of lies.

Dialogue(Mick): Kael! Thank the stars... tell them! Tell them about the contract! Tell them I'm good for the eddies!

Dialogue(Kael): Mick, you're a goddamn disaster. I'm surprised they haven't zeroed you yet.

Dialogue(Moxie Leader): He's a monster of a different kind, merc. A deceiver. He took their time, their hope, and their "services". Now, he pays in synaptic feedback.

Choices:

1. How much to settle the tab? [5000 EDDIES] **(Go to SCENE FOUR-A)**
2. He's not worth the electricity. Let me take him, or I'll start breaking your chrome. **(Go to SCENE FOUR-B)**
3. [TECHNICAL: 15] Look at his neural-port. It's fried. He's a brain-dead glitch, not a millionaire. You're wasting power. **(Go to SCENE FOUR-C)**

SCENE FOUR-A:

Dialogue(Kael): How much to settle the tab? I need his hands for a job, and I don't have the patience to wait for his nervous system to reboot after you've fried it into scrap.

Dialogue(Moxie Leader): (Checks a digital display) Five thousand eddies. That covers the girls' time, the premium booze he charged to the room, and the emotional distress he caused by promising them a ticket off this rock. It's a steep price for a man who can't keep his stories straight.

Dialogue(Kael): (Inhales) It’s a steep price for a man whose brain is mostly pulp, but I’m a man of my word. Transferring the credits now. Unstrap him before I decide the five grand is better spent on your medical bills.

Description: The Moxie Leader checks her HUD, a satisfied smirk crossing her face as the transaction clears. She taps a command on her wrist-link, and the magnetic locks on the chair hiss open. Mick falls forward out of the chair, sobbing as he hits the floor, clutching his temples.

Dialogue(Mick): I... I really did love them, Kael. Every single one. I wasn't just lying... I was giving them something to believe in!

Dialogue(Kael): Shut up, Mick. You weren't giving them hope; you were giving them a reason to kill you. Get to the safehouse. If I hear one more word about "love" or "orbital colonies," I’ll hand you back to them for free.

SCENE FOUR-B:

Dialogue(Kael): He’s not worth the electricity. Step aside and let him go, or you’ll find out exactly how many holes my silver-plated rounds can put in that expensive chrome.

Dialogue(Moxie Leader): (Laughs) You Witchers—or whatever you call yourselves these days—are all the same. Emotionless bastards hiding behind a badge and a gun. You think you can walk into Westbrook and dictate terms to us? Over a piece of shit like Mick?

Dialogue(Kael): I’m not here for a lecture on morality from a street-gang executioner. I have a job to do. Mick is part of that job. If you’re in the way, you’re just another obstacle to be cleared.

Dialogue(Moxie Leader): Big talk for a man standing in a small room surrounded by four hungry blades. You want to play the martyr for a liar? Fine. We’ll use your bones to decorate the next "Romeo" who walks through that door! Girls, show him why we run this district!

Description: Combat sequence. Kael versus the four Moxes. The room becomes a blur of sparks and muzzle flashes as Kael moves with unnatural speed. After the fight, Kael steps over the sparking remains of the security tech and manually overrides the chair, releasing a trembling Mick.

Dialogue(Kael): Get up, Mick. If you ever make me choose between an army and your pathetic life again, I’m choosing the army.

Dialogue(Mick): I... I didn't think they'd actually fry me, Kael! I had everything under control!

Dialogue(Kael): You had nothing under control. You’re lucky I need your hands for the safehouse, otherwise I’d have left you here to rot in that chair. Now move, before more of them show up to finish what these girls started.

SCENE FOUR-C:

Dialogue(Kael): [TECHNICAL] Take a long look at his neural-port. See that pulsing amber light? His sub-processors are already redlining. He's a walking glitch, a brain-dead server with no eddies in the bank and even fewer in his pocket. You're burning high-grade electricity on a man whose credit is as dead as the scavs I just pulled off the pier.

Dialogue(Moxie Leader): Internal diagnostics... shit. You're right. His synaptic load is zero. He's been playing us since he walked in, hasn't he?

Dialogue(Kael): He's a professional liar, but even a pro can't hide a fried motherboard. You want to waste your power and your girls' time on a man who won't even remember his own name by midnight? Or do you want to let me take this piece of junk off your hands so you can clear the room for a customer who actually has a wallet?

Dialogue(Moxie Leader): Fine. Take him. He's not worth the synaptic wear and tear on my equipment. But tell your "Romeo" this: if I see his face in Westbrook again, I won't use the chair. I'll just pull his spine out through that fancy neural-port and sell it for scrap.

Description: The Moxie Leader shuts down the terminal. The magnetic locks on the chair hiss and release. Mick slumps forward, barely catching himself on the floor. Kael grabs him by the collar and hauls him up.

Dialogue(Kael): You heard the lady, Mick. You're officially garbage. Now get to the safehouse before she changes her mind and decides to see what your spine is worth on the open market.

Dialogue(Mick): I... I had them convinced, Kael! I just needed a little more time to...

Dialogue(Kael): You don't have time, and you definitely don't have luck. Move.

SCENE FIVE:

Description: The North Oak construction site is a graveyard of unfinished corporate ambition, dominated by a massive, vertical garbage processing shaft that drops into the dark like a hungry throat. Kael stands at the edge, peering down into the abyss where the stench of rotting plastic and industrial chemicals rises in waves. He activates his optics, scanning the depths. Far below, a faint, flickering distress signal pings against his HUD. He kicks a piece of loose rebar into the hole; it takes several seconds to hit the bottom.

Dialogue(Kael): Slim? You still breathing down there, or did the trash finally claim its own?

Dialogue(Slim): Kael? Is that you? Goddammit, watch your step! I'm pinned under a hydraulic compressor. My cyber-legs are jammed, and the Scav-drones are starting to circle.

Dialogue(Kael): Always in a hole, Slim. Literally or metaphorically. Hold tight. I'm coming down.

Description: Kael secures a heavy-duty winch cable to a structural beam and begins a rapid descent. Halfway down, the hum of engines fills the shaft. Four "Cyber-Rats"—security drones with jagged, makeshift blades—emerge from the shadows of the wall, their red sensors locking onto Kael.

Dialogue(Kael): Great. Automated pest control.

Description: Combat sequence. Kael hangs from the cable with one hand, firing his revolver with the other as the drones dive-bomb him. Once the drones are sparking scrap at the bottom, Kael reaches the floor and finds Slim half-buried under a mountain of industrial waste. He kneels, examining the crushed actuators in Slim's legs.

Dialogue(Kael): This doesn't look like an accident, Slim. You were hiding. Who was chasing you?

Dialogue(Slim): Does it matter? They had corporate badges and better chrome than me. I took a shortcut through the shaft and the floor gave way. Just... just fix the damn legs so I can get out of this grave.

Dialogue(Kael): (Inhales) I can bypass the locks, but you're going to be walking with a limp until we hit a real ripperdoc.

Choices:

1. Redirect the power from your optics to your legs. You'll be blind, but you'll be able to climb. **(Go to SCENE FIVE-A)**
2. I'll carry you out. But it's going to cost you double when the job is over**. (Go to SCENE FIVE-B)**
3. If I can't fix them, I'm leaving you. I don't carry dead weight. **(Go to SCENE FIVE-C)**

SCENE FIVE-A:

Dialogue(Kael): I'm rerouting your optical feed. Your internal battery is a joke, so I'm forcing the power to focus entirely on the leg servos. You won't see a thing—total blackout—but you'll have enough torque in those actuators to move.

Dialogue(Slim): Do it. I'd rather be blind and moving than a sitting duck in a trash can waiting for the scav-drones to finish the job.

Description: Kael jams a diagnostic link into Slim's neck port. Slim's eyes flicker and go dark, but his hydraulic legs hiss as the fluid begins to circulate with a violent force. Kael hauls him up, bracing him against the wall of the shaft.

Dialogue(Kael): Grab my belt and don't let go. We're climbing this winch cable. If you slip or your grip fails, don't expect me to dive back into the abyss for you. I'm not a martyr, Slim.

Dialogue(Slim): Just get me to the safehouse, Kael. I'm done with the scenery down here. I can't see the exit, but I can damn sure feel the cold.

Dialogue(Kael): You're alive. That's more than you deserve for hiding in a garbage chute. Move.

SCENE FIVE-B:

Dialogue(Kael): (Inhales) I'll carry you out. But don't think this is a charity rescue. It's going to cost you double when the job is over. I don't risk a spinal blowout for free, and I certainly don't do it for a "thank you."

Dialogue(Slim): (Coughs) Double? Kael, I'm half-buried in a trash heap and you're already haggling like a damn corpo-repo man.

Dialogue(Kael): The price is for the weight, Slim. If you don't like the rate, you can stay here and wait for the garbage compactors to do their work. Either way, the shaft gets cleared.

Dialogue(Slim): Fine! Done! Just get me out of this hole before the Scavs come back for seconds.

Description: Kael secures Slim to his back with the winch cable, his exo-skeletal frame groaning under the added mass. He begins the slow, punishing climb back up the vertical shaft as the structure around them creaks.

Dialogue(Kael): Don't get comfortable. The moment we hit the surface, you're finding your own way to the safehouse.

Dialogue(Slim): Just keep climbing, Kael. You're lucky I'm too tired to complain about the service.

SCENE FIVE-C:

Dialogue(Kael): I'm checking the link again, but if I can't bypass these locks, I'm leaving you. I don't carry dead weight, and I'm not about to get zeroed by a corporate hit squad because you can't walk on your own two feet.

Dialogue(Slim): Kael, wait! You can't just leave me here to be recycled! We've been through too much for you to just drop me like a burner phone!

Dialogue(Kael): We've been through enough for you to know how this works, Slim. I'm not a martyr, and I'm definitely not your guardian angel. If you're too broken to move, you're just a liability. I'd rather slay a few more scavs on my own than drag a corpse up a trash shaft.

Dialogue(Slim): You soulless bastard! People were right about you... no feelings, just a machine with a gun!

Dialogue(Kael): Call me what you want, but I'm the one who's going to be breathing fresh air in five minutes. Farewell, Slim. Hope the compactors are quick.

Description: Kael turns his back on the debris, grabbing the winch cable. He begins his ascent without looking back. Below, the flickering red lights of new drones start to emerge from the darkness as Slim's shouting fades into the sound of grinding metal.

SCENE SIX:

Description: The Watson tech district is a landscape of humming neon and black-market circuitry. Kael stands outside a heavily fortified ripperdoc clinic. The front windows are shuttered behind thick security mesh. In the alleyway, a local server hub glows with a sickly blue light, guarded by two Corporate Tax Enforcers in heavy tactical gear. They are leaning against their patrol vehicle, bored but armed with high-grade thermal rifles. Pete is visible through a side window, pacing like a caged animal in his workshop.

Dialogue(Kael): Pete. I heard you were having some trouble with the "legal" side of the business.

Dialogue(Iron Pete): (Voice crackling over the intercom) Legal? It's a goddamn shakedown, Kael! Those corporate leeches locked my workbench behind a digital seal. Every lathe, every 3D-printer, even my personal neuro-calibrator. They say I owe "Protection Taxes." If I don't pay, they're going to seize the lot and sell it to some Militech puppet.

Dialogue(Kael): (Inhales) I don't care about your debts, Pete. I need a gunsmith who can actually work, not one who's staring at a locked screen.

Dialogue(Iron Pete): Then get me my gear! The digital key is in that server hub outside. Or just zero those two corporate lapdogs and take the physical bypass. I can't leave without my tools—they're the only thing that makes me more than just another mouth to feed in this shithole city.

Dialogue(Kael): Fine. Stay out of the line of fire. I'm not paying for your funeral.

Choices:

1. I'll hack the server hub and wipe the debt. No one needs to die today**. (Go to SCENE SIX-A)**
2. I don't have time for a data-dive. I'll kill the enforcers and take the bypass. **(Go to SCENE SIX-B)**

3. Pay the "Protection Tax" [8000 EDDIES]. I’m buying your freedom, Pete. Don't make me regret it. **(Go to SCENE SIX-C)**

SCENE SIX-A:

Dialogue(Kael): I’ll hack the server hub and wipe the debt. Stealing is cleaner when you don't have to wash the blood off your boots. No one needs to die for a corporate rounding error today.

Dialogue(Iron Pete): You always did prefer the ghost route. Just watch your back—the ice on that server is thick enough to freeze your brain solid. If they catch you in their subnet, they'll fry your nervous system before you can even jack out.

Description: Kael crouches behind the server hub, hidden from the enforcers' line of sight. He jacks into the terminal through a personal link. A digital sequence follows as he bypasses the corporate security layers, rewriting the tax records in real-time. After the hack, the blue glow of the hub turns a neutral white, signaling a successful wipe. Inside the shop, the heavy machinery hums to life as the digital seals vanish.

Dialogue(Kael): The debt is gone, Pete. You’re officially a ghost in their system. They won't even find a record of your name in the morning. Take your gear and vanish.

Dialogue(Iron Pete): You’re a goddamn magician, Kael. I’m packing the last of the calibrators now. I’m moving. See you at the rendezvous.

Dialogue(Kael): Just make sure you aren't followed. I'm not doing this twice.

SCENE SIX-B:

Dialogue(Kael): I don't have time for a data-dive. Stealing from the corps is easier when the people guarding the door are too dead to file a report.

Dialogue(Iron Pete): That’s the Kael I remember. Soulless as a piece of cold iron. Just make it quick—their backup is only five minutes out, and they don't send the "junior" squad for stolen tech!

Description: Kael draws his high-caliber revolver. Combat sequence. Kael versus the two Corporate Tax Enforcers. The alleyway erupts in gunfire as Kael uses the shadows for cover, moving with a predator's efficiency. After the enforcers are zeroed, Kael loots a high-security bypass chip from one of the steaming bodies and slams it into the clinic’s exterior terminal. The workshop doors hiss open as the magnetic locks fail.

Dialogue(Kael): The locks are dead. Grab your equipment and get to the safehouse. I'm not sticking around to explain the mess.

Dialogue(Iron Pete): I knew I could count on you, you heartless bastard. See you at the rendezvous. Don't die on the way—I still need to see the look on the twins' faces when we pull this off.

Dialogue(Kael): Just move, Pete.

SCENE SIX-C:

Dialogue(Kael): I'm paying the "Protection Tax." Eight thousand eddies. I'm buying your freedom, Pete, so don't make me regret this by getting zeroed before the job even starts.

Dialogue(Iron Pete): Eight grand? Kael, you're a madman. That's more than my life is worth on a Tuesday! Where did a heartless merc like you get that kind of scratch?

Dialogue(Kael): I'm not paying for your life. I'm paying for your hands and the specialized gear in that shop. The credits are transferred. Now open the damn door before the corps decide to hike the rate.

Description: The Corporate Tax Enforcers check their tablets, the transaction light turning green. They exchange a bored look, signal the remote override, and step back toward their vehicle. The security mesh over the clinic retracts with a heavy, mechanical grind. Pete emerges from the shadows of the workshop, hauling a massive tech-crate filled with his king-tier tools.

Dialogue(Iron Pete): I don't know why you're being so generous, but I'm not complaining. You saved my legacy, Kael. I'll make sure your gear is the sharpest in Night City for this.

Dialogue(Kael): Just move. We're already behind schedule and I didn't pay eight thousand eddies to stand in an alleyway and chat.

SCENE SEVEN:

Description: The Nomad bar is a hollowed-out shipping container parked in the middle of a dust-blown Nowhere. Outside, a sandstorm howls, sand-blasting the rusted metal. Inside, the air is thick with the smell of cheap synthetic whiskey and diesel. The twins, **Jax and Dax**, are sat at a scarred heavy-metal table, surrounded by empty bottles and a crowd of cheering Nomads. They are identical, save for the different corporate logos etched into their matching cyber-arms. They are locked in a heated drinking contest, ignoring the world until Kael shadows their table.

Dialogue(Jax): Look at this, Dax. A city-slicker merc made it all the way out to the dust-bowl. You lost, Kael? Or did you just run out of neon to stare at?

Dialogue(Dax): He's here for the job, Jax. I can smell the desperation and the high-grade neuro-chem from here.

Dialogue(Kael): I'm here because the crew is scattered like scrap in a hurricane. I need the two of you sober enough to hold a rifle. We have work to do.

Dialogue(Jax): Work? We're in the middle of a celebration! We don't leave a party this good for a "maybe" contract.

Dialogue(Dax): Unless... you're feeling lucky. A little bilekgüreşi. You beat us, we follow you to the gates of Arasaka Tower. You lose, you pay our tab and leave your sidearm as a trophy.

Dialogue(Kael): My sidearm stays with me. But if a match is what it takes to get you moving, let's get it over with.

Choices:

1. I'll take you both on. One arm each. Let's see if that chrome is just for show. **(Go to SCENE SEVEN-A)**
2. I'm not here to play games. How much is the tab? [3000 EDDIES] **(Go to SCENE SEVEN-B)**
3. [STREET CRED: 20] Look at me. Do I look like I have time for a bar fight? The loot on this job is better than this rotgut. **(Go to SCENE SEVEN-C)**

SCENE SEVEN-A:

Dialogue(Kael): I'll take you both on. One arm each. Let's see if that high-priced chrome is actually worth the eddies, or if it's just for show.

Dialogue(Jax): Bold talk for a man whose joints sound like they need a gallon of WD-40! Clear the table, boys! Let's see if the merc's servos can handle the pressure!

Description: The crowd roars as Kael locks hands with the twins. The sound of metal grinding against metal fills the bar as Kael's internal hydraulics whine under the strain. A quick-time event follows. With a final surge of power, Kael slams both their arms into the table, cracking the reinforced surface.

Dialogue(Kael): Now. Are we done with the festivities, or do I need to break the table with your heads?

Dialogue(Dax): Synthetic hell... alright, Kael. You made your point. Our arms—and our rifles—are yours.

Dialogue(Jax): We're moving. Just let us grab our gear.

Dialogue(Kael): Meet at the safehouse. Don't stop for another drink, or I'll come back and finish what I started with the table

SCENE SEVEN-B:

Dialogue(Kael): I'm not here to play games or provide free entertainment for a crowd of drunks. How much is the tab?

Dialogue(Dax): Three thousand eddies. Covers the whiskey, the broken chairs, and the "hospitality" fee for the house. It's a small price to pay to keep the peace and get us off these stools.

Dialogue(Kael): Transferring the credits. Consider your debt to this rust-bucket settled. Now get your gear and get to the safehouse before I decide to deduct this bribe from your final cut of the contract.

Description: Kael taps his internal port, authorizing the transfer. Jax and Dax watch their huds as the transaction clears. They exchange a look, then drain the last of their glasses, slamming them onto the table. They stand up, the heavy thud of their boots echoing in the hollow container.

Dialogue(Jax): You always were a generous bastard, Kael. Even if you act like you've got a block of ice where your heart should be.

Dialogue(Dax): We're moving. We'll meet you at the rendezvous. Just don't expect us to be happy about the lack of booze.

Dialogue(Kael): I expect you to be ready. Move.

SCENE SEVEN-C:

Dialogue(Kael): Look at me. Do I look like a man who has the time or the patience for a bar-room brawl? The loot on this contract is worth more than every bottle of rotgut in this dust-bowl combined. You can stay here and drown in the Badlands, or you can get up and take a real score.

Dialogue(Jax): I know that face. You're the one who zeroed that corporate hit-squad in Watson. Rumors said you were a ghost.

Dialogue(Dax): If Kael is here in person, the job isn't a "maybe." It's a funeral for someone with a very deep pocket.

Dialogue(Kael): It's a funeral for anyone who gets in our way. Now, are you coming, or am I finding a crew that actually wants to be rich?

Description: The twins exchange a silent look, the playful drunken energy vanishing instantly. They stand up, kicking their stools back. The rest of the Nomads go quiet, sensing the shift in the room.

Dialogue(Jax): We're in. If the pay is half as good as the trouble you usually bring, it'll be enough to buy a new rig.

Dialogue(Dax): Meet you at the safehouse, Kael. We'll bring the heavy ordinance.

Dialogue(Kael): Don't be late. I'm starting the briefing at midnight, with or without you.

SCENE EIGHT:

Description: The safehouse is an abandoned server farm in the industrial heart of Santo Domingo. The air is cold, smelling of ozone and old dust. One by one, the crew filters in. Mick is twitching, his optics still dim from the chair. Slim limps heavily on his bypassed legs. Iron Pete is hauling a tech-crate that clatters against the concrete. Finally, Jax and Dax lean against the wall, their heavy rifles slung over their shoulders. Kael stands in the center of the room, his shadow long under a single flickering floodlight.

Dialogue(Iron Pete): Look at this lot. We look less like a crew and more like a scrapyard waiting to happen.

Dialogue(Mick): At least we're alive. I thought Kael was going to let those Moxes turn my brain into a circuit board.

Dialogue(Jax): He probably would have, if he didn't need you to hack the final gate. Kael doesn't do "mercy." He just does "math."

Dialogue(Slim): Speaking of math, Kael, you owe me a real ripperdoc. These legs are screaming.

Dialogue(Kael): You'll get your repairs and your eddies when the job is done. Until then, you're functional. That's all I need.

Dialogue(Dax): Enough with the crying. Kael, you got us here. Now tell us what kind of "god" we're supposed to kill to get paid.

Description: Kael steps forward and activates a holographic projector. The blueprints of a high-security corporate vault bloom in the center of the room, bathing their faces in a cold blue light.

Dialogue(Kael): It’s a simple extraction. But the security is run by an AI that doesn't believe in "survivors." We go in tonight.

Dialogue(Iron Pete): Then I guess it’s a good thing we brought the "monsters" with us.

Dialogue(Kael): *Inhales.* Cut the crap! Gear up boys! We are going to burn the city to the ground!